

Chapter 2 - Rebirth

If she wasn't dreaming now, then she must have gone mad, Ning Fuyi thought as she stood stiffly in place.

Everything before her eyes defied common sense. First, dead people and destroyed places all appeared before her, then there was some damned marriage contract—between her and Chu Qingqiu?

If spoken aloud, it would surely make people laugh until they cried. Who didn't know that Ning Fuyi hated Chu Qingqiu? And who didn't know that Chu Qingqiu was her mother's white moonlight, the Condensing Heaven Sect Master, and a senior whose cultivation exceeded hers by a thousand years?

Even as a demon lord, she found this matter utterly absurd.

After standing for a long while, Ning Fuyi sneered coldly: "Chu Qingqiu, what kind of joke are you playing?"

She tried forcefully to pull her hand back, but after struggling for a long time, Chu Qingqiu's two fingers remained completely motionless.

The feeling of being without demonic power was truly awful. Ning Fuyi cursed again in her heart.

However, her movements were too rough, and the cloth wrapped around her body slipped down to her chest. When her supple skin was exposed, Chu Qingqiu's gaze drifted for an instant before she finally released her grip and turned away.

Ning Fuyi quickly retreated several steps, splashing up quite a bit of water.

"If you violate the heavenly laws, the light punishment would be sixteen heavenly thunderbolts, the severe punishment would be complete annihilation. If you think I'm speaking nonsense, you're welcome to try."

As she spoke, Chu Qingqiu slowly walked onto the shore. Her steps were steady, but if one looked carefully, one could see her footing was unsteady, unlike usual. She extended her palm and turned it slightly—the water stains on her body instantly disappeared, and a cloud-fluff-like cloak draped over her shoulders, swaying without wind.

"Master..." Qiu Yi at the side quickly stepped forward to support her, but was blocked by Chu Qingqiu's outstretched hand.

Naturally, Ning Fuyi didn't dare try easily. Not to mention that she currently couldn't beat Chu Qingqiu at all, even if she could, she wouldn't dare. If a dignified demon king lost her life because of some damned marriage contract, it would be laughably pathetic.

So she temporarily stood quietly in place, looking around again to assess the surrounding environment.

A luminous jade stone was embedded in the ceiling, illuminating the cave brightly. The jade's light was like sunlight refracting on the pool bottom, still rippling and flowing. The stone pillars beside the cold pool were so polished they could reflect one's image.

She was all too familiar with this place. In her childhood, her mother had entrusted Chu Qingqiu to teach her. At that time, Chu Qingqiu had heartlessly thrown her into the cold pool to force her to use it for cultivation practice. She had cried and wailed in the pool water for three days before being taken back by her mother.

After returning to her room, she had run a high fever for three whole days.

So Ning Fuyi had feared Chu Qingqiu since childhood.

Looking now, this was indeed the former Bone-Scattering Cold Pool. Ning Fuyi suddenly had a bold guess in her heart, so she pinched herself hard, the pain almost making her mouth go crooked.

Now that old friends had reappeared and familiar places had returned, this wasn't a dream, and the pain all over her body, as if she'd been beaten up, didn't seem fake either.

Could it be that her formation hadn't resurrected the dead, but had caused her to be reborn?

Thinking of this, even Ning Fuyi couldn't help but be stunned for a long while. Shocking waves surged from her ice-cold limbs toward her heart, and for a moment her heartbeat was like beating drums.

She quickly summoned what little immortal power she had in her body, struggling for a long time to conjure a bronze mirror, which she held up to examine herself carefully.

Phoenix eyes, glass-like pupils, slightly curled hair bound high up, a palm-sized face—not the cold and stunning appearance of her past life, but still carrying unshaken youthful innocence.

Wasn't this exactly how she looked as a young girl? Ning Fuyi felt a surge of joy. She leaned closer to examine herself carefully, and with her sharp eyes discovered that the two symmetrical teardrop moles¹ at the corners of her eyes from her previous life had now vanished without a trace.

Her originally graceful figure had also become flat as a board, which somewhat disappointed Ning Fuyi.

"Master, look at this stubborn wretch. You kindly saved her, yet not only does she show no gratitude, she actually attempts to commit insubordination against you, and even, even..." Qiu Yi was so angry she could barely speak, "attempts to... take liberties with you! How utterly audacious!"

Ning Fuyi was staring absent-mindedly at herself in the mirror when she heard these words. She suddenly lowered her hand and raised an eyebrow at Qiu Yi.

After being caught by her gaze, Qiu Yi felt an inexplicable panic in her heart for an instant. She forcibly steadied her steps, secretly puzzled. Usually, she looked down most on this so-called Young Sect Master of Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, thinking her willful, playful, and talentless—simply unworthy of her position.

But that look just now was vicious and terrifying, making her inexplicably feel a chill.

"Saved me?" Ning Fuyi looked toward Chu Qingqiu. The woman was sitting with eyes closed on a rattan chair, faint flying feathers floating around her, seemingly exercising her power to heal injuries.

From Chu Qingqiu's pale complexion, her injuries were not light.

"Otherwise, what do you think you'd be standing here for? If it weren't for that sect disciple insisting on kneeling and begging Master, how could Master possibly interfere in your sect's internal affairs?" Qiu Yi stepped forward to block Chu Qingqiu, cutting off Ning Fuyi's line of sight.

A sect disciple? Begging Chu Qingqiu? Ning Fuyi feared exposing the fact of her rebirth and didn't dare ask more, so she crossed her arms and used what little immortal power she had to examine her own body, momentarily shocked.

She had indeed suffered very serious injuries—her immortal meridians were almost completely destroyed, then mysteriously reconnected. Although she was now weak and had consumed a large amount of immortal power, her life was no longer in danger.

Looking again at Chu Qingqiu's frowning, enduring appearance, she believed it somewhat.

But how could someone as cold-hearted and emotionless as Chu Qingqiu, who had severed all emotional ties, risk damaging her own cultivation to save her?

"What day is it today?" Ning Fuyi was too lazy to deal with Qiu Yi and asked directly.

"What, did getting injured damage your brain too?" Qiu Yi crossed her arms disdainfully. "Isn't there a big event happening at your Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate today? Even people from the Penglai Realm² have sent representatives. If not for this, my Master was cultivating peacefully—why would she end her seclusion early?"

A big event? Ning Fuyi stepped forward urgently: "What big event?"

Qiu Yi was startled by her suddenly raised voice and quickly retreated two steps, defensively raising her curved blade: "What are you being so jumpy for? How would I know about your sect's affairs?"

Though she wouldn't say, Ning Fuyi already had an answer in her heart. She herself had suffered serious injuries, and there was also a great upheaval at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate. Could it be...

The day her mother died.

She would never forget this day—the fourth day of the third month, just two days before the Qingming Festival³.

Her mother had qi deviation⁴ in front of her, her immortal body completely destroyed, while she herself was also seriously injured. All the sect elders had been deliberately led away, leaving her with no one to save her—she nearly went to see the King of Hell. Fortunately, her good friend Liu Wenzhu knelt to the death at the Liu family's gate, using her life to force the Liu family head to save her.

It was also tonight that she had dragged her sick body to kneel outside Chu Qingqiu's door all night, begging her to go see her mother, yet hadn't been able to wait for any response.

It was just that now she didn't know if she had truly been reborn, or if this was a trap set by others. If it was real, wouldn't she be able to...

Ning Fuyi's heart suddenly surged with excitement, so she pinched herself once more to steady her emotions.

If it was real, wouldn't she be able to do it all over again and prevent some of the tragedies that occurred in her previous life?

Thinking of this, Ning Fuyi suddenly walked quickly toward Chu Qingqiu. A cold light flashed before her, and Qiu Yi's curved blade was instantly angled at her throat, blocking her path.

"What are you trying to do now!" Qiu Yi raised her head and rebuked.

"Isn't it a marriage contract? You form a marriage contract with me, yet won't let me come near—what's the reasoning in that?" Ning Fuyi stood in place without moving an inch, her voice silky smooth, her fingertip lightly touching the curved blade to feel the coolness.

"You let..."

Qiu Yi was speaking when she was suddenly interrupted. The Chu Qingqiu who had been exercising her power had already lowered her hands, her dark eyebrows slightly furrowed: "Qiu Yi, let her come over."

Qiu Yi looked unwilling but didn't dare disobey the order. She could only glare fiercely at Ning Fuyi and step aside huffily to make way.

"The marriage contract was a last resort. It will naturally be dissolved later—you need not concern yourself with it," Chu Qingqiu said indifferently.

"How do I know if what you're saying is true or false?" Ning Fuyi tilted her head, hair falling from her forehead, her black pupils bottomlessly deep.

Something seemed to flash in Chu Qingqiu's eyes. Her eyelashes trembled, and she looked away, though her voice remained cold: "True or false, what harm is there to you?"

"I don't know about harm, I only know it makes me sick," Ning Fuyi suddenly lowered her voice, speaking at a volume only the two of them could hear.

The young girl's eyes revealed hatred and arrogance that didn't belong to someone of her age. Chu Qingqiu's fingertips unconsciously curled, and only after a long while did she relax them again.

"Ning Fuyi." Chu Qingqiu seemed to be angered. Her expression didn't change, but the furrows between her brows deepened.

Seeing her anger, Ning Fuyi finally lowered her head, pretending to have misspoken momentarily. But her body wasn't obedient—instead, taking advantage of Chu Qingqiu's unpreparedness, she suddenly leaped up and flashed toward her.

The two were too close together; Qiu Yi couldn't stop her in time and could only let out a sharp scream, watching helplessly at Ning Fuyi's audacious behavior.

Most surprisingly, Chu Qingqiu didn't dodge at all. She merely tilted her head slightly and let herself fall naturally, like a gracefully shaped cloud, overturning the rattan chair and quietly landing on the ground.

Ning Fuyi, with quick eyes and hands, pulled open the button on Chu Qingqiu's collar and with another tug, exposed the skin within that had never been scorched by the blazing sun.

That patch of skin was clean and pure, only inexplicably tinged with some redness, like thin clouds at dawn.

When she had imprisoned Chu Qingqiu before, to humiliate her, she had carved a peach blossom on her shoulder. Now this peach blossom had vanished without a trace.

Ning Fuyi reached out again, her palm approaching that smooth-as-silk skin.

The situation had been urgent before and she hadn't paid attention, but now she could clearly sense the faint warmth that the marriage contract brought when their skin touched.

She had originally worried this was an illusion Chu Qingqiu had created to destroy her consciousness, but now this worry was completely shattered.

She had indeed been reborn.

"Have you seen enough?" Chu Qingqiu's eyes were tinged with red as she spoke coldly.

The next instant, Ning Fuyi was overturned to the ground by a gust of air. A sharp killing intent struck, and relying on reflexes honed over many years, she retreated in the opposite direction, barely dodging the strike.

The curved blade left a deep crater in the dragon crystal-paved ground. Qiu Yi's figure descended from the sky along with the curved blade, seemingly determined to slice Ning Fuyi in half.

However, Ning Fuyi didn't dodge anymore. She crouched in place, calmly watching the approaching Qiu Yi. She knew well what kind of person Chu Qingqiu was—full of righteousness and concern for all living beings, she would never allow her disciple to kill randomly.

Otherwise, she wouldn't dare be so presumptuous.

Sure enough, just as the curved blade was about to touch Ning Fuyi, a flying feather came from the side, deflecting the blade's force as if using minimal effort to redirect great strength.

With a clang, the curved blade fell straight to the ground. Wind lifted Ning Fuyi's half-dry long hair, revealing her smiling yet not-smiling, clearly defined profile.

"Master..." Qiu Yi protested urgently, but after seeing Chu Qingqiu's expression, the remaining words stuck in her throat, and she could only angrily stop her attack.

Chu Qingqiu at the side had already stood up, her slender fingers clutching her collar, covering the lingering blush on her neck. She looked at Ning Fuyi with anger, then waved her hand. Flying feathers spun toward them, transforming into white ropes.

Before Ning Fuyi could react, she was already bound to a stone pillar by these ropes. Then came endless pressure, like heavy hammers striking her skull. Even Ning Fuyi broke out in a cold sweat from the pain.

"Do you know your fault?" Chu Qingqiu's voice sounded without much fluctuation, but her slightly trembling fingertips revealed just how angry she was at the moment.

A wise person submits to circumstances. Ning Fuyi immediately changed her expression, putting on the appearance of being frightened, tilting her head and shouting: "Divine Venerable, spare my life! This disciple knows her fault!"

She was certain of her rebirth, so she was now just a young girl with mediocre talent, with no power to contend against Chu Qingqiu. It was better to go with the flow—preserving her life was important.

Thinking this way, she acted even more convincingly. Her thin body trembled, disheveled hair covering her reddened cheeks. The demonic expression from before had completely vanished. Due to the pain, she shed a few drops of sweat, her red lips bright as fruit, looking somewhat pitiable.

Sure enough, the severe pain at the top of her head stopped abruptly. Only then did Ning Fuyi have a moment to breathe heavily. When her breathing calmed, she turned and looked up. A faint fragrance slid past her nose, and her heartbeat was suddenly startled into skipping a beat.

She saw Chu Qingqiu was half-kneeling in front of her, the breeze lifting her scattered hair, so close that Ning Fuyi could see her own reflection in those eyes.

Ning Fuyi instinctively tried to retreat, but her chin was grasped and firmly fixed in place, the grip making her skin ache.

Footnotes:

¹ **Teardrop moles (泪痣)** - Small moles positioned near the corners of the eyes, traditionally considered to be signs of beauty and sometimes associated with romantic fate in Chinese culture.

² **Penglai Realm (蓬莱境)** - Penglai is a legendary mystical island in Chinese mythology, often associated with immortals. In cultivation novels, it typically refers to a powerful immortal sect or realm.

³ **Qingming Festival (清明)** - Also known as Tomb Sweeping Day, a traditional Chinese festival where people honor their ancestors by visiting graves and making offerings. It usually falls in early April.

⁴ **Qi deviation (走火入魔)** - In cultivation fiction, this refers to a dangerous condition where a cultivator's energy goes haywire during practice, often leading to madness, serious injury, or death. It's usually caused by emotional disturbance, improper technique, or forced cultivation.